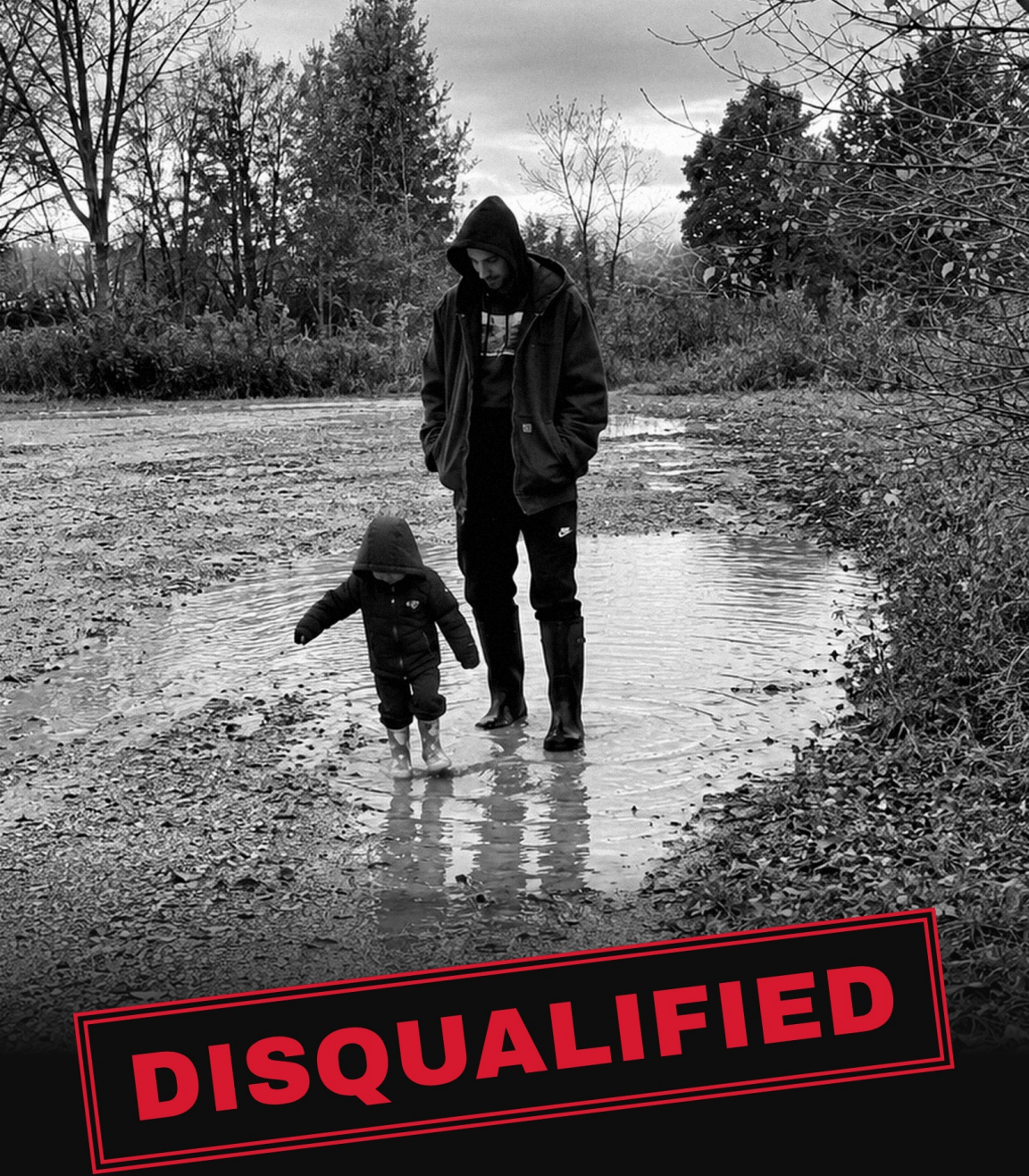


DISQUALIFIED

From Financially Clueless to Financially Free

One Hard Lesson at a Time

LUKE VASILION

DISQUALIFIED

From Financially Clueless to Financially Free,
One Hard Lesson at a Time

FREE SAMPLE

LUKE VASILION

What's in this sample

Thanks for grabbing this. Here's the opening of the book, one full chapter, and the 30-day plan that pulls every move from the book into one checklist.

Every chapter works the same way: what happened, then *What I know now*, the money lesson in plain English with real numbers, then *Your move this week*, a few small things you can do in the next seven days.

This book is my story and what I learned from it. It's not financial, legal, tax, or investment advice, and I'm not a licensed financial advisor. Talk to a qualified professional before big decisions.

— Luke

Disqualified

Something you should know about me up front: when I get my mind set on something, I don't just want it. I *have* to do it. It's not always a great quality. Ask my wife.

At 24, the thing I'd set my mind on was the Army. Not just the Army, either. 18X, the Special Forces enlistment option. I'd been bouncing between jobs I didn't like, I was unhappy, and I wanted to do something that meant something. So I went all in. Trained for it. Studied for it. Signed the contract. Bria, who has followed me into more crazy ideas than any reasonable person should, went all in right alongside me. Our lease was ending. My job was ending. I was supposed to ship out pretty much right after.

All that was left was the medical pre-screen at MEPS, which is where the military checks that your body can cash the checks your paperwork wrote.

Part of that is a hearing test. You sit in a little booth, put on some headphones, and push a button every time you hear a beep. That's it. It's the least dramatic test ever invented. I was more worried about the paperwork.

Beep. Click. Beep. Click.

Then they switched to my left ear, and things got real quiet. Like, suspiciously quiet.

I had no idea. I'd noticed some ringing in that ear before, but I figured everybody had that. Turns out everybody does not have severe tinnitus and most of the hearing in that ear gone. I do. I still live with it every single day. Back then, all I knew

was that the Army has a tolerance for hearing loss, and I was outside it.

Disqualified.

Now, remember what I said about getting my mind set on things? Yeah. I did not take that well. I went to civilian doctors. I got more tests. I went back to MEPS more than once to fight it, every time thinking this was the one. It wasn't. Eventually they stopped saying "disqualified" and started saying "permanently disqualified," which I'm pretty sure is Army for *please stop coming here.*

And just like that, the plan was gone.

Except the lease was still ending. The job was still ending. We had nowhere to live, no income lined up, and about two months of money before we'd be completely broke. And I had to go home and tell Bria that the plan we'd built our whole life around didn't exist anymore. She'd trusted me with all of it without a second thought, like she always does.

That was the worst part. Not the ear. Not the Army. Looking at her.

If you take one thing from this book, take this: **you need a Plan B before you need a Plan B.** Not some vague idea in the back of your head. Actual money in the bank. Skills somebody will pay for. Options. Because life doesn't text you a heads-up before it pulls the rug out, and "two months from broke" is a lot closer than most people think, no matter what they make.

Quick disclaimer before we go any further. I'm not a financial advisor. I wasn't born on third base thinking I hit a triple. I'm a kid from the Lansing area who grew up on food stamps, made a whole pile of dumb money decisions, and figured most of this out the hard way. Today I lead a front-end team

building software used on NASA missions, and between that and the businesses I've built on the side, we gross somewhere between $15,000 and $30,000 most months. No car payments. No credit card debt. I'm going to walk you through every step in between. Including the stupid ones. *Especially* the stupid ones. There's a Dodge Challenger in here that still makes me wince.

But to explain how I ended up in that hearing booth, and how we climbed out of the hole after, I've got to go back to the beginning.

To two houses, two completely different lives, and a kid switching between them every other week.

In the full book, the story picks up here with Chapters 1 through 6: two houses, working at 14, paying for college without loans, and a first tech job in Austin. This sample skips ahead to the car that still makes me wince.

Chapter 7: The Challenger, and the Truck That Got Me Out

Every money book needs a villain. This is mine.

When I was 22, working at GM, I bought a 2009 Dodge Challenger R/T for about $17,000.

I paid too much for it. I knew I was paying too much for it. I did not care, because it was a Challenger, I was in my early twenties, and it was a manual. If you've ever bought something purely because of how it made you feel in the parking lot, you already know how this story goes.

Shortly after I bought it, Dodge came out with the Demon: a factory drag-racing version of the Challenger with a price tag most people could only dream about. Hardly anybody could buy one. But it didn't matter. When the new top dog showed up, everything underneath it slid down a rung. The SRT came down in value, and so did the R/T, which is what I had. My car didn't change one bit. It just stopped being the cool one overnight.

Within about a year, it was worth roughly half of what I'd paid, and I was about **$9,000 upside down**. That means I owed the bank about $9,000 more than the car was worth. If I'd sold it that day, I'd have handed over the car *and* still owed somebody $9,000 for the privilege of having driven it.

That's not a car. That's a very fast way to set money on fire.

The truck that got me out

Here's where it gets interesting, and where I did something kind of smart in the middle of something really dumb.

Working at GM came with a perk: employee pricing on new vehicles. Real discounts, well below what normal people pay.

So I did the thing every financial expert tells you never to do. I traded the Challenger in and rolled the negative equity into a loan on a brand-new truck.

I know. I know. Hear me out.

Usually, rolling negative equity into a new loan is how people dig the hole deeper. You take your old debt, stack it on top of a brand-new vehicle that starts losing value the second you drive it off the lot, and now you're even more underwater than before. It's a trap, and dealerships love it.

But the employee discount changed the math. Because I was getting the truck so far below its market value, the discount soaked up a big chunk of the hole from the Challenger.

I drove that truck for a while. When it was time to get out of it, I was still upside down. I had to write a check for about **$2,000** to let it go.

Was that fun? No. But $2,000 upside down beats $9,000 upside down every single day of the week. I turned a $9,000 mistake into a $2,000 lesson. Not a win. Just a smarter loss.

And that's the thing I'm proudest of from that whole era. Not that I avoided the mistake, because I clearly didn't. It's that, even in the middle of it, the kid from Menards was still in there somewhere, doing the math and looking for a way out.

What I know now: cars are built to lose money

The most important thing to understand about cars is this: **almost every car is a depreciating asset.** That's a fancy way of saying it loses value every single day you own it. Rare collector cars aside, the car you buy today will be worth less tomorrow, less next year, and a lot less in five years.

A common rule of thumb is that a new vehicle loses about 20% of its value in the first year, then roughly 15% a year for the next few years. Every vehicle is different, but here's what that looks like on a $40,000 truck:

	Worth about	Lost so far
Day you buy it	$40,000	$0
After 1 year	$32,000	$8,000
After 2 years	$27,200	$12,800
After 3 years	$23,100	$16,900
After 5 years	$16,700	$23,300

That truck lost more than half its value in five years. That's money you'll never see again, and because it doesn't show up on a bill, most people don't think about it.

Why rolling negative equity is usually a trap

Now let's see what happens when somebody does what I did, without a GM employee discount to bail them out.

Say you owe $20,000 on a car that's only worth $14,000. You're $6,000 upside down. You trade it in on that $40,000 truck, and the dealer rolls your $6,000 into the new loan: $46,000 at 7% for six years. Your payment is about $784 a month.

	You owe	Truck is worth	Upside down
Day one	$46,000	$40,000	$6,000
After 1 year	about $39,600	about $32,000	about $7,600

You made twelve payments, about $9,400 total, and you're **more** upside down than the day you started. That's the trap. The old debt never went away. You just bought something new to stack it on, and the new thing started losing value faster than you could pay it down.

The only reason my version wasn't a disaster was that I bought the new truck well below its value. Without a deal like that, don't do it. If you're upside down, the honest answer is usually to keep the car you have and pay it down until you're not.

The real cost of a car

The payment is just the part they show you. Here's what a vehicle really costs per month, using example numbers:

	Per month
Loan payment	$600
Insurance	$150
Gas	$200
Maintenance and repairs	$75
Registration and fees	$15
True monthly cost	**$1,040**

And that's before depreciation, the invisible cost from the table above. When someone says "my truck is $600 a month," it's almost never $600 a month.

Your move this week

1. **Find out if you're upside down.** Look up what your car is worth today on Kelley Blue Book or Edmunds. Then check your loan payoff amount with your lender. If you owe more than it's worth, you're upside down, and now you know exactly by how much.
2. **Add up your true monthly car cost.** Payment, insurance, gas, maintenance, and fees. Write down the real number.
3. **If you're upside down, stop the bleeding.** Don't trade it in. Keep it, and if you can, throw a little extra at the loan each month until you're right-side up. The fastest way out of the hole is to stop digging.

Your First 30 Days

Here's every move from the book, in the order I'd actually do them. You don't have to be perfect. You don't even have to finish every one. But if you work through this list over the next 30 days, you'll be further along than I was at 25.

Each step tells you which chapter it came from, in case you want the why behind it.

Week 1: See where you stand

You can't fix what you won't look at. This week is just about looking.

- **Write down your reason.** Who or what are you doing this for? Put it somewhere you'll see it every day. (Chapter 18)
- **Write down your money rules.** The ones your parents said out loud and the ones they showed you. Circle the ones you still follow. (Chapter 1)
- **Find your real hourly rate.** Take-home pay, minus what it costs to get to work, divided by every hour the job really takes. (Chapter 3)
- **List every monthly payment you have.** Balance, interest rate, and payment for each. Add them up, then multiply by 12. (Chapter 6)
- **Check your credit report** for free at annualcreditreport.com. Look for errors and anything you forgot about. (Chapter 6)
- **Find out if you're upside down on your car,** and add up what it really costs you each month. (Chapter 7)

Week 2: Build the safety net

This is your Plan B before you need a Plan B.

- **Calculate your runway.** Add up your monthly essentials, then divide your savings by that number. (Chapter 8)
- **Open a high-yield savings account** and name it "Emergency Fund" or "Plan B." If your savings are sitting somewhere that pays close to nothing, move them. (Chapters 8 and 12)
- **Set your first target:** $1,000 or one month of essentials, whichever comes first. (Chapter 8)
- **Write one money goal** with three parts: what it's for, how much, and by when. Give it its own account. (Chapter 2)
- **Pay yourself first.** Set up automatic transfers for the day your paycheck lands, even if it's only $25. (Chapter 3)

Week 3: Stop the leaks

Now that you can see where the money goes, start pointing it where you want it.

- **Rate your five biggest expenses** from 1 to 10 on how much they actually improve your life. Cut or shrink the lowest one. (Chapter 11)
- **Call one company you pay every month** and ask for a better rate. (Chapter 5)
- **Pick avalanche or snowball,** pick your first target, and throw something extra at it. Even $25 starts the clock. (Chapter 6)
- **If you're upside down on your car,** don't trade it in. Keep it and pay a little extra until you're right-side up. (Chapter 7)

- **If you have student loans,** look up how much interest you'll pay over the life of each one. (Chapter 4)

Week 4: Start building

This is where your money starts working for you instead of the other way around.

- **Check your 401(k) match.** If you're not getting all of it, raise your contribution until you are. (Chapter 10)
- **Open a Roth IRA if you're eligible,** and look up one S&P 500 index fund and what it charges. (Chapter 10)
- **Write a one-page investing plan,** then set up automatic investing on a set day. (Chapter 13)
- **Look up what your job pays** and your total compensation. Find one skill that would move you up, and update your resume. (Chapters 9 and 15)
- **Have the money talk** with your partner, and write down three rules you'll both follow. (Chapter 16)
- **List three skills you could charge for,** and open a separate account for side income. (Chapter 17)

Day 31

Pick the one move that scared you most and do it again next month. Then keep going.

You've got this.

Want the rest of the story?

The full book has all 18 chapters: two houses and food stamps, working at 14, the hearing booth, starting over at $10 an hour, the COVID crash I watched from the sidelines, buying NVIDIA on the way down, the house flip, the raise that changed nothing, and running a family on one income.

leavingthematrix.io/disqualified

PDF and EPUB, $9.99, instant download. Also on Amazon in Kindle and paperback.

And if you want the stories as they happen, I post new videos every Tuesday and Friday at **youtube.com/@LukeVasilion**.